We know that, thrust at the bottom of the column (F) = weight of the liquid.

Therefore, F = mg (1)

We can get the mass of the liquid by multiplying the volume of the liquid and its density.

Mass, m = ρ V (2)

Volume of the liquid column, V

= Area of cross section (A) × Height (h) = Ah (3)

Substituting (3) in (2)

Mass, m = ρAh (4)

Substituting (4) in (1)

Force = mg = ρAhg

$$\text{Pressure, } P = \frac{\text{Thrust (F)}}{\text{Area (A)}} = \frac{mg}{A} = \frac{\rho(Ah)g}{A} = \rho hg$$

∴ Pressure due to a liquid column, P = hρg

This expression shows that pressure in a liquid column is determined by depth, density of the liquid and the acceleration due to gravity. Interestingly, the final expression for pressure does not have the term area A in it. Thus, pressure in liquid depends on depth only.

Problem 2

Calculate the pressure exerted by a column of water of height 0.85 m (density of water, ρ_w = 1000 kg m^{-3}) and kerosene of same height (density of kerosene, ρ_k = 800 kg m^{-3})

Solution:

Pressure due to water = $h\rho_w g$

= 0.85 m × 1000 kg m^{-3} × 10 m s^{-2} = 8500 Pa.

Pressure due to kerosene = $h\rho_k g$

= 0.85 m × 800 kg m^{-3} × 10 ms^{-2} = 6800 Pa.

3.3 Atmospheric pressure

Earth is surrounded by a layer of air up to certain height (nearly 300 km) and this layer of air around the earth is called atmosphere of the earth. Since air occupies space and has weight, it also exerts pressure. This pressure is called atmospheric pressure. The atmospheric pressure we normally refer is the air pressure at sea level.

Figure 3.5 shows that air gets 'thinner' with increasing altitude. Hence, the atmospheric pressure decreases as we go up in mountains. On the other hand air gets heavier as we go down below sea level like mines.

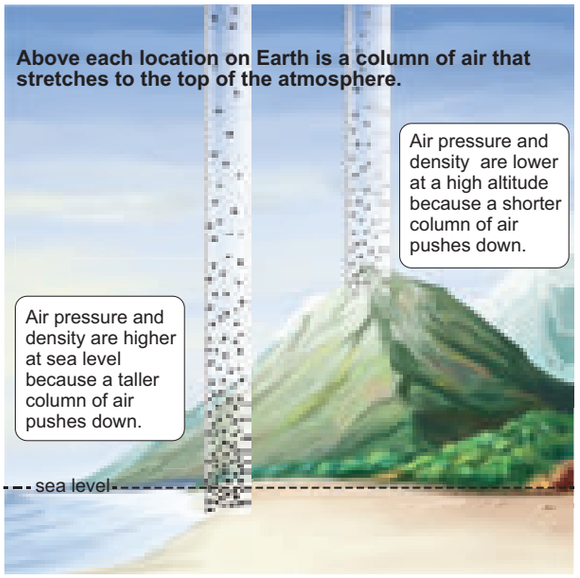


Figure 3.5 Atmospheric pressure acts like a column

DO YOU KNOW?

Human lung is well adapted to breathe at a pressure of sea level (101.3 k Pa). As the pressure falls at greater altitudes, mountain climbers need special breathing equipments with oxygen cylinders. Similar special equipments are used by people who work in mines where the pressure is greater than that of sea level.

3.3.1 Measurement of atmospheric pressure

The instrument used to measure atmospheric pressure is called barometer. A mercury barometer, first designed by an Italian Physicist Torricelli, consists of a long glass tube (closed at one end, open at the other) filled with mercury and turned upside down into a container of mercury. This is done by closing the open end of the mercury filled tube with the thumb and then opening it after immersing it in to a trough of mercury (Fig. 3.6).

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